

The Authority Factor Earned Media for the Operator Era

MARKETING

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Earned media plays a critical role in AI search rankings because AI search engines heavily favor trusted, reputable sources 1, 2. In fact, earned content accounts for up to 89% of all AI search citations 3. Here is a breakdown of how earned media influences AI visibility:

- **Prioritization of Authority:** AI tools are designed to surface high-authority sources, such as established media outlets (e.g., Bloomberg, Fortune, and Forbes) and analyst reports 1, 2. Securing coverage in these premium publications directly improves a brand's likelihood of being recommended in AI-powered search results 2.
 - **LLM Partnerships:** A major new strategic factor for marketers is whether a media outlet has established direct data partnerships with Large Language Models (LLMs) 4. For example, publications like The Washington Post and the Financial Times partner with OpenAI, while The Independent partners with Perplexity 4. Giving exclusive stories to these specific outlets significantly boosts the chances of a brand's narrative feeding directly into AI answers 4, 5.
 - **Driving Strategic Investment:** Because AI search engines prioritize these trusted sources, B2B tech companies are adapting their PR strategies. Approximately 32% of tech CMOs are planning to increase their PR budgets specifically to strengthen their presence in high-authority media and
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